extension of coastlines, the exposure of continental shelves and the formation of connecting land-bridges. Subsequent deglaciation involved at least three significant meltwater pulses, when huge quantities of trapped water were suddenly released. The last of these is reckoned to have taken place between 8200 and 7600 years ago, with a central peak during which sea levels are believed to have risen by some seven metres within a space of 150 years.[15] So it is entirely possible that in about 6000 BCE human settlements located off Kanyakumari, the Malabar coast and in what is now the Gulf of Cambay could have been engulfed by some form of tsunami.

Memories of such traumatic events would certainly have been passed down through the generations. But it does not follow that an advanced civilisation was lost to the sea. It is quite feasible that one or more rudimentary settlements were established on the exposed shelf off the present Kanyakumari eight thousand years ago. What is entirely unrealistic is to credit them with a degree of sophistication capable of supporting literary assemblies of the kind ascribed to the first two Sangams.

The best evidence of the state of Tamil society at the time of the late Iron Age that I am aware of comes from an extensive urn-burial cemetery at Adichallanur, on the south bank of the Thamirabarani River some 25 miles (40 kilometres) inland. This was first excavated by Dr Alexander Rea, Superintending Archaeologist of the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI), between 1889 and 1903. His digs uncovered numerous urn burials, each containing complete human skeletons in squatting positions, together with many grave goods, including swords, spears and metal utensils. ‘The objects yielded by these burial sites,’ Rea wrote, ‘are finely made pottery of various kinds in great number; many iron implements and weapons; vessels and personal ornaments in bronze; a few gold ornaments; a few stone